Rest Area

By Clay McLeod Chapman

GRACE'S DAD: *(talking to a family through the window of a car)* **(Pg 1-8)** Carolina plates. You guys have come far. Where you heading? Out Midwest? Lord, that's a long haul. And with the whole family, boy. Who's the little tinker in the backseat? Hi there. She doesn't mind being buckled up all day? Good for her. My daughter and I did our own bit of venturing cross-country this summer, just the two of us. We ambled along the back roads for weeks.

Could you tell me if you've seen her? Here. *(holds out a flyer)* Here's a photograph of her. Well, a photocopy. You can't make out her features very well. But if you look here, right above the smudge, you can still spot her smile. That's Grace's smile.

I'm pasting them up all along here. On the soda machines. There's a whole stack with the tourist pamphlets. Just in case someone's seen her. Can't be

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too sure, now.

You didn't, did you? Did you see a girl on the road? Red hair, Cream shorts. No sign of her?

INTRODUCTION

When you're traveling on a long road trip, a rest stop can provide a much-needed break and an opportunity to recharge your batteries; especially if you are traveling alone with children. Unfortunately, because they are often in isolated locations where help is many miles away, rest areas are not always safe.

*The last thing anyone wants to think about is a child being abducted, but it's a harsh reality. *According to the Child Crime Prevention and Safety Center, "each day 33 children are abducted by someone who is not a family member."*

What should you do if your child is missing? Immediately call local law enforcement. But that's not what happens in Rest Area by Clay McLeod Chapman and we begin to wonder why.

GRACE'S DAD: *(directly to audience members as if they are travelers)* We drove through here a few months ago, about halfway into our trip. The A/C was on its own time, leaving us with the windows down for most of the ride. The heat wasn't the problem, really. I could've dealt with that. It's the puddle of sweat forming at the

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stem of your neck that drowns your temper. The wet itch you get all along your scalp. Let your nerves juggle that, while your girl is in the seat next to you. Trust me, it doesn't make for a calm, cool ride. Grace had found a couple candy bars in the glove compartment, which had been sitting in there for God knows how long. At ninety what-not degrees, they melted into this ropy tar she didn't mind lapping off the wrapper. It found its way onto every part of her face except her mouth. Her hands left chocolate on the windows. She got caramel on the seat belt that still hasn't come out.

The rest stop was five miles away. We pulled into the third slot, down at the far end there. It was mid-afternoon, so this place was full of enough people to not see any particular person. I don't think I made eye contact with *one single person*.

My shorts had crawled up my waist, so the upholstery was clinging to my thighs. Grace is giggling at my hairy legs – these chunks of half-melted chocolate dangling from her teeth. She didn't understand what all the hours in the car had done to my patience, mistaking my

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irritation for some game. I wasn't talking, so she flipped on the radio, turning the volume up to some harsh static – only to smear chocolate on the dial.

That was it. My boiling point had hit. I told Grace to get out of the car. Slamming doors, deep sighs – the entire routine. Pointing to the curb, I told her to wait while I ran to the men's room.

I come back with a whole roll of toilet paper, finding Grace on the curb, crying. She's doing a better job at washing off her cheeks than I could've, the tears tasing more sweet than salty. We must have moped around for a few minutes, until she slaps a thick hand print of candy right across my cheek. I reach my tongue around to taste it, licking the bottom side of her palm clear off. I keep going back for more of her until there's none left. She's giggling again, so I start swiping the chocolate off her cheeks, too – until she's tickled back into having a fun time.

Good, I think.

A few sniffles later and she asked to wash up in the

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ladies' room.

She took the keys with her. Fetched them right out of my hand. They didn't fit in hers, poking out between her knuckles. It was as if her fingers had multiplied all of a sudden. I remember Grace walking down the sidewalk here – this stop-and-run between all the other families. She'd gallop along until someone walked in front of her, whinnying in place while they passed by, and then pick up her stride again once the path was clear. The farther she went, the more those keys sounded like spurs pushing her along. I watched her slip off into the crowd, and I remember wanting to keep looking at her. I'd stash the memory of this place I the trunk, with all our luggage. She would come back to me, and we would take that highway. Take it to wherever it led us.

I found more handprints wrapped around the seat. There were chocolate fingers pointing in all directions, navigating the toilet paper into deep crevices. Wherever I'd bury it, my hand would come up gooey, gummy. The candy wouldn't let go of the car,

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stretching out in long strands of caramel – only to lash back onto the upholstery. Even the sweets didn't want to let her go.

Five minutes passed and I fumbled for my watch. There was no sign of her. No smell of her. No taste anymore.

Women kept walking in and out from the bathroom, while I waited outside the door. That picture nailed to the front, that symbol or whatever you'd call it. She's a taunter, that's for sure. A stick figure in a skirt marking the ladies' room. She could have been a man wearing a dress for all I knew. But I'm watching her slip away and slide right back at me while all these women kept coming in or coming out. But none of them were *her*. I asked some lady if she'd see if Grace was still in there, but she came out shaking her head. There were dirty looks from everyone inside, but I had to walk in. I called out Grace's name at every stall. I kneeled down in hopes of finding her legs hanging in front of me. I just wanted to see familiar feet. Cream short down at her ankles. That's all.

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No one had seen her at the vending machines. All the picnic tables had other families sitting at them. I'd spot a girl on her own and I'd think it was Grace. I'd run to her. The closer I got, the more the shorts wouldn't match, or her hair would turn a color off right in front of me. She wasn't waiting at the car. The phone booths were full of teenagers necking with each other. The walls had everyone else's name scrawled over them, but not Grace's. The parked cars kept switching with fresh ones. But I wouldn't let anyone drive off until I looked through their windows. Until I knew that she wasn't inside. I kept searching. Kept asking. Kept calling out, "Grace! Daddy wants to leave now!"

But that was months ago. Now I can't remember which finger of mine touched her last. What part of me she kissed before running off. All I see now are people on their way somewhere else, tangling up into each other long enough to relive themselves. And then they leave. While I'm still here. You'd think people could remember seeing a face like hers. A head of hair as red as that, she could light her way through a crowd.

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That's her, that's what she looks like. Sprinkle her with some freckles and she's good enough to eat. They're covering her cheeks, leaving her looking like a chocolate chip cookie. See that? She's smiling at the idea. This is the best photocopy of her, I think. All of these smudges could be sweet, if I rubbed them right. Because I'm sure she's still got a bit of candy on her face, somewhere. Think of the black parts of the picture as chocolate. And then you've got my girl.

You're coming through here at a pretty good time, now. This place emptied out about an hour or so ago. The weekend traffic thinned itself down to the serious drivers, like yourself. IF you want soda, the vending machines are that way. I think I finished off most of the snacks yesterday, so I don't know how good your selection will be. The man who refills them doesn't com back until Thursday, so . . . sorry. My meals don't stray too far from potato chips and pop, but I'm not complaining. With the few handprints of Grace's still stuck on the car, you'd think I could scrape off a meal for myself. But I'd just end up smudging what's left of her over the upholstery. I want to keep her there for as

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long as I can. Let her fingers point me in the right direction.

I'm sure she thinks this is all some sort of game. That's what I get for starting our vacation off by feasting on the states. You can't help but choke once you forget to chew. And now I've got a bone in my throat that won't slip up the highway or down it.

I know she's still here. Caught right above the Adam's apple, you could say. I've become so used to this place, even the people are looking alike now. I'm sure the same cars have driven through here two times over, at least. And I can't even find my keys. I've spent days looking for them, peering up underneath the stalls when no one's around. Getting real familiar with the plumbing. I feel like I have more in common with the drainage here than anything else. Their pipes are probably as clogged as mine are. Eating from these vending machines has left my insides feeling stiff. The fifty-cent foods here have become the staple in my diet, while the toilet feeds off of whatever I drop for it.

So there are a hundred and one different places she

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could be. Who's to say I've looked through them all? You have the woods, the toilets, the tourist info. All these cars.

Our car. It's been sitting there in the same parking spot for so long now, she has to know where it is. I've left a trail of candy wrappers for Grace, just in case. She couldn't miss it if she closed her eyes. It's been there for so long, it's staring to smell. I didn't think cars could rot, but ours is somehow. I haven't been able to get into the trunk, where all of our luggage is, so I'm thinking she might've brought along some pet and just not have told me.

It's these games. I can't keep up with them. I feel like I'm in the middle of one now, but I'll be damned if I'm not the last to know.

We're playing out a fairy tale here. I can't get to my shaving kit, so I've become some rest-area troll for her to hide from. I catch a glance of myself in the bathroom, or find my reflection in the rearview mirror. It's hard now to recognize what's staring back. It's hairy all over and just as scared as I am. It has an ordor that

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follows me around, strongest in the places that I want to sleep. It's taken over the car with such a stink – letting me know that it's been there and will stay there for as long as it's parked in this place. And this is the part I have to play, while Grace is the princess running away, hiding from me. She has the keys, so she makes the rules. I can't leave until I find her. And I know she's close. God, sometimes I can almost smell her underneath all of this, she feels so close.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
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Source Information for Data in the Introduction

https://childsafety.losangelescriminallawyer.pro/missing-and-abducted-children.html#:~:text=Every%2040%20seconds%2C%20a%20child,percent%20of%20these%20are%20children

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